

China e-commerce

EQUITY: INTERNET & NEW MEDIA

E-commerce sales accelerated slightly in May

Quick Note

China e-commerce sales growth accelerated slightly to 2.6% y-y in May

The National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) on 16 June 2026 released China's retail sales data for May 2026. China's retail sales (excluding auto sales) grew 1.1% y-y (down from 1.8% in April) to CNY3.8tn in May, during which China's e-commerce sales (excluding sales of services) rose 2.6% y-y to CNY1.2tn, accelerating from 0.2% y-y growth in April. E-commerce penetration in China deepened 1.0pp y-y to 31.6% in May.

Based on NBS data, China's online food and beverage sales rose 15.5% y-y in 5M26, on par with the 15.6% y-y growth in 4M26. Online apparel sales recorded a 7.2% y-y increase, up from 6.8% y-y growth in 4M26. Online sales of household goods increased 1.6% y-y in 5M26, decelerating from 2.6% y-y in 4M26.

In terms of sales for the entire retail market (including both online and offline), within staples, food sales and daily necessity category rose 1.9% and 1.6% y-y, respectively, in May, decelerating from 4.1% and 3.5% y-y in April. However, beverage sales recorded growth of 6.1% y-y, accelerating from the 3.6% y-y increase in April.

Within the discretionary category, subcategories growth trends are diverging. The decline in PC sales narrowed to -1.5% in May from -6.9% in April, and home appliance category posted a 15.6% y-y sales decline in May, little change from the 15.1% drop in April, weighed down by high base effects and dwindling trade-in subsidies, in our view. Smartphone sales edged up 0.7% y-y in May, decelerating from the 6.2% y-y growth in April, mainly due to high base effect and recent price hikes in mobile devices triggered by memory chip cost inflation. Apparel sales recorded a 3.8% y-y increase in May, comparable to the 3.6% y-y growth in April, while cosmetic sales growth decelerated to 2.5% y-y in May, from 4.7% y-y in April.

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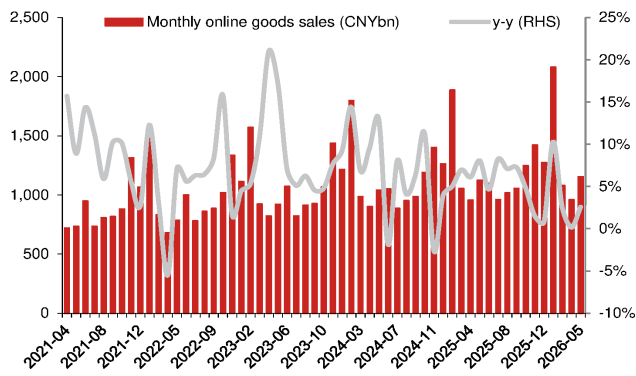
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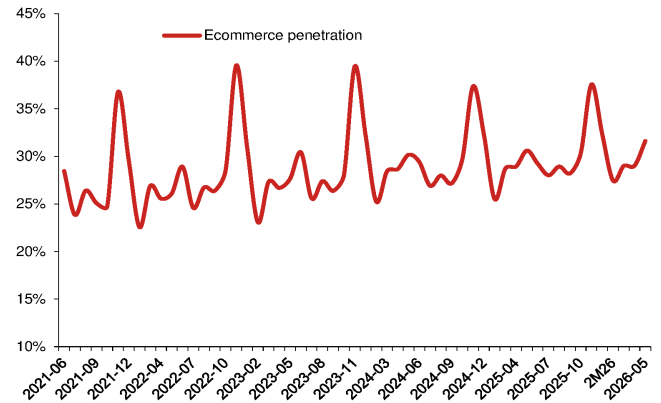
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Fig. 1: China: Monthly online goods sales and y-y growth



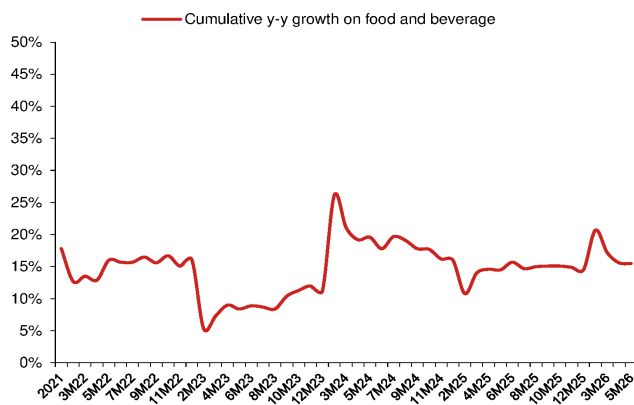
Note: Excluding sales of virtual goods.
Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 2: E-commerce as a percentage of total retail sales



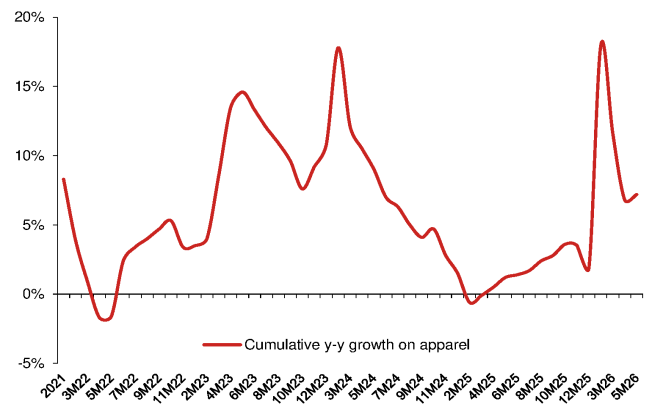
Note: Excluding sales of virtual goods.
Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 3: Cumulative y-y growth of online retail sales of food and beverages



Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 4: Cumulative y-y growth of online retail sales of apparel



Source: NBS, Nomura research

Appendix A-1

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As at 31 March 2026.

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